

HOATZIN

The hoatzin is an enigmatic South American bird that has an entirely vegetarian diet of leaves.

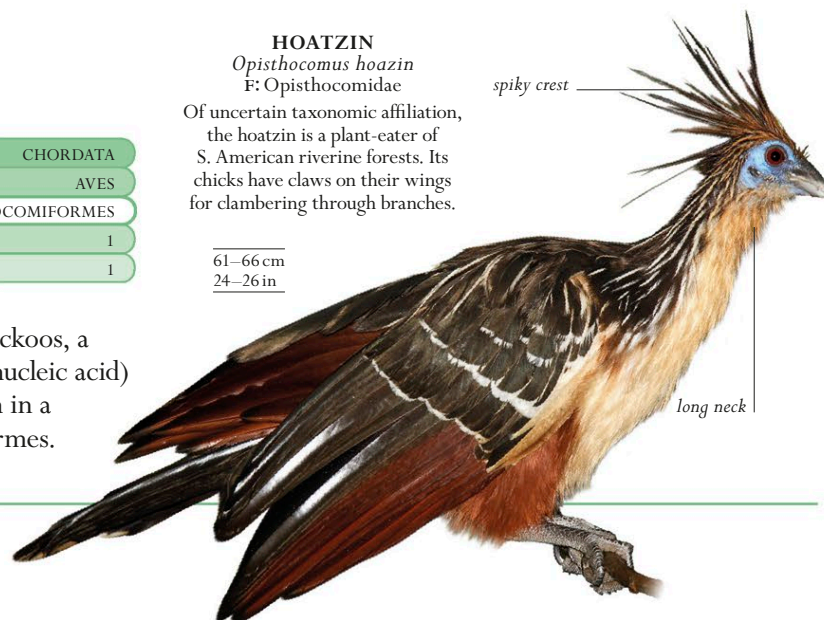
Some features of the hoatzin, such as strong feet and a short, curved bill, are similar to those of gamebirds. However, the hoatzin also shares features with cuckoos, a relationship that appeared to be confirmed by early DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) studies. Later research has thrown doubt on this – leaving the hoatzin in a group of its own, the only representative of the order Opisthocomiformes.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	OPISTHOCOMIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	1

HOATZIN
Opisthocomus hoazin
F: Opisthocomidae

Of uncertain taxonomic affiliation, the hoatzin is a plant-eater of S. American riverine forests. Its chicks have claws on their wings for clambering through branches.

61–66 cm
24–26 in



spiky crest

long neck

CUCKOOS

Cuckoos are rather short-legged, long-winged, mostly softly feathered birds that include dull, greyish species as well as a small group with patches of vivid emerald green.

All members of the Cuculiformes have feet with two toes pointing forwards and two backwards. The most primitive cuckoos are heavy-bodied American birds that forage on or near the ground – a lifestyle taken to the extreme by the sprinting roadrunner. In spite of their reputation, not all cuckoos lay their eggs in other birds' nests.

Almost all these ground cuckoos build nests and raise their own young, as do their Old World counterparts, such as the tropical coucals and couas. Cuckoos that lay eggs in nests of other bird species are called “brood parasites”. Remarkably, this habit has evolved independently at least twice in Old World cuckoos. The chicks of crested cuckoos (*Clamator* sp.) outgrow their host nest so quickly that host chicks die from starvation. Another line of cuckoos, which includes the Eurasian common cuckoo, evolved chicks with more murderous intent: they actively eject host eggs and chicks.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	CUCULIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	149



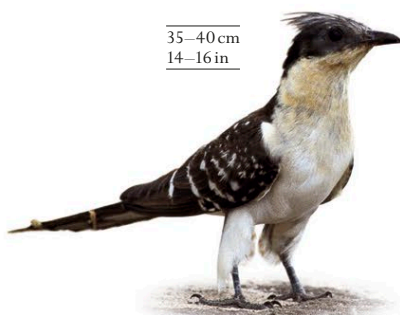
thick, black bars on belly

long wings

28–34 cm
11–13½ in

HIMALAYAN CUCKOO
Cuculus saturatus
F: Cuculidae

This species from Asia and Australia is typical of a group of Old World barred cuckoos that resemble sparrowhawks – a fact that perhaps helps them to flush hosts from nests.



35–40 cm
14–16 in

GREAT SPOTTED CUCKOO
Clamator glandarius
F: Cuculidae

With a range from Europe to Africa, this cuckoo lays eggs in magpie nests, but, like other *Clamator* species, does not evict the host's young.



34 cm
13½ in

JACOBIN CUCKOO
Clamator jacobinus
F: Cuculidae

Clamator cuckoos are large crested Old World cuckoos. Like others, this tropical species from Africa and Asia eats hairy caterpillars that are avoided by competitors.



32–34 cm
12–13½ in

COMMON CUCKOO
Cuculus canorus
F: Cuculidae

This widespread Eurasian species overwinters in Africa and S. Asia. It has the well-known “coo-coo” call that gives cuckoos their name.

FAN-TAILED CUCKOO
Cacomantis flabelliformis
F: Cuculidae

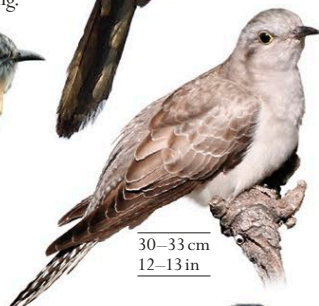
This brown-breasted cuckoo of Australasian woodlands is one of very few cuckoos that are found in the Pacific – and the only one in Fiji.



24 cm
9½ in

GREY-BELLIED CUCKOO
Cacomantis passerinus
F: Cuculidae

Found from the Malay Peninsula to Australia, this bird is one of many Indo-Pacific, brown-breasted species that are closely related to *Cuculus* cuckoos.



30–33 cm
12–13 in

PALLID CUCKOO
Cacomantis pallidus
F: Cuculidae

Many Old World cuckoos have barred plumage, but in some, such as this Australian species, the barring occurs only in immature birds.



23 cm
9 in

BRUSH CUCKOO
Cacomantis variolosus
F: Cuculidae

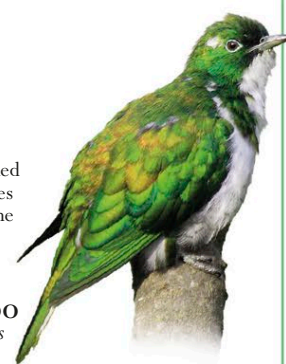
Related to Asian brown-breasted cuckoos, this plain-coloured species breeds in southern Asia. The montane populations migrate to warm lowlands in winter.



17–19 cm
6½–7½ in

DIDERIC CUCKOO
Chrysococcyx caprius
F: Cuculidae

An African member of a group of small bronze-sheened tropical cuckoos, this species lays its eggs in the nest of the weever bird.



16–18 cm
6½–7 in

KLAAS'S CUCKOO
Chrysococcyx klaas
F: Cuculidae

This small African cuckoo is a close relative of the dideric cuckoo, differing in being greener and lacking white wing spots.